digital transactions for millions of users across India over the last 2.5 years. These experiences overall have shaped my journey and career trajectory, and they've also underscored the profound impact that technology can have on society when harnessed effectively and ethically.

Q What is the stumbling block for tech innovation in India?

I'll start by acknowledging that India has made significant strides in very recent years. The number of patent applications and patents granted, I think, crossed the six-digit mark - 100,000 patents - the previous financial year, which is like a threefold improvement over the previous years. But that said, there is still so much to be done to truly excel in this area and catch up with the leaders in the US and China. In my mind, there are a few steps that India needs to take:

One is to emphasise quality over quantity. India must focus on the quality of inventions in addition to the number, and this can be achieved through education at the grassroots level. We need to encourage innovation where it often happens unnoticed. By fostering this culture of creativity and critical thinking from an early age, we can nurture a generation of innovators.

The second is India needs to streamline its patent evaluation process. We need to increase the manpower dedicated to evaluating patent applications. That is crucial to reduce the time taken to review and approve these applications. Currently, the time required to process patent applications in India is still longer than in the US or China. Also, regular training for patent examiners is essential so that they can stay updated with evolving technical knowledge and become SMEs themselves.

The third would be investments in R&D for emerging technologies. India needs to step up its investment in research and development, particularly in sunrise technologies, because these are the technologies that will help India consistently maintain a double-digit growth rate for the next 25 years. These investments should be genuine, focused on creating meaningful advancements, not merely for marketing purposes.

And finally, I think we need mature intellectual property recognition. India must become a mature nation in recognizing and enforcing intellectual property rights. This means accelerating the recognition and enforcement of patents to align with global standards. Quick and fair enforcement will encourage more innovators to file patents domestically.

So, addressing these few areas, I think India can significantly enhance its patent production. We are already number 5 on the list and can become a leader in innovation on the global stage.

Q So the problem isn't one of lack of talent?

That's right. A lot of the innovation in our experience happens at an early stage of any project and at that stage, these innovative ideas often go unnoticed. So, if we nurture that critical thinking at an early stage, then we can create a generation of inventors. We do have the skills, the manpower, and even the data in this country. But there are some nuances that we need to address here to cross the line.

Q What's the Indian government's incentive in protecting IP and fostering tech innovation?

The Indian Government has a 25-year roadmap, right? India in 2047, 100 years of independence, and we want to be as close as possible to being the biggest economy in the world. To grow, we need to sustain a double-digit growth rate for many years, so 10% over the next 25 years. In order to achieve this, it's clear that we have to invest in sunrise technologies, right? Exponential technologies as they are called, not only in the traditional technologies like textiles and manufacturing. It has to be the new tech: AI, data, Generative AI, blockchain, metaverse, and whatnot. When we talk about this, IP protection becomes key, because intellectual property is the big fuel. In order for us to climb the scale in terms of size of economy, there is a correlation between that and the amount of IP friendliness that our country has. When I say IP, it is also publishing more papers in conferences and journals and producing more PhDs and so on. So, we'll have to catch up with the leaders in all these fields.

Q Any message for India's young tech innovators?

I would say that to have a great career in technology, you have to fall in love with the field. As you progress from early-stage career to mid-career, shift your focus from depth of experience to breadth of perspective. In the early years, focus on gaining depth in multiple domains. Be a bit of a rolling stone and gradually acquire breadth. I think that is key. Throughout a long career spanning 35-40 years, you will encounter tech disruptions and discontinuities. That is a given, but foundational skills such as algorithms, mathematics, and statistics will endure, and they will keep you ready for opportunities over the long term. Finally, mastering the art of multitasking without feeling overwhelmed can be immensely rewarding as well. d